University of Jena
Department of English and American Studies
Winter 2017-18

Daniel Jach
Ernst-Abbe-Platz 8, 607, Tuesday 17-18 p.m.
03641-944545, daniel.jach@uni-jena.de

Cognitive English Grammar

BA.AA.SW05
Tuesday, 2 - 4 pm
Carl-Zeiß-Straße 3, SR 128
5 ECTS

(Sunset at a flooded rice field, by Simon Wong)

Seminar Description

> In elementary school, I was taught that a noun is the name of a person, place, or thing. In college, I was taught the basic linguistic doctrine that a noun can only be defined in terms of grammatical behavior, conceptual definitions of grammatical classes being impossible. Here, several decades later, I demonstrate the inexorable progress of grammatical theory by claiming that a noun is the name of a thing.
>
> (Langacker, 2008, p. 93)

The study of grammar is essential to the study of language, yet, often considered artificial, formalistic, and out of touch with the reality of language use and learning, and often feels like the desperate attempt to use a straight ruler to measure curves, zigzags, circles, and any shape but a straight line. In this seminar, students will be introduced to what is known as Cognitive Grammar (Langacker, 1987, 1991). Proponents of Cognitive Grammar assume that the grammar of a language arises from dealing with experiences of language use and interaction. As a consequence, grammar is meaningful. In the course of the semester, students will learn to define and explain basic concepts of Cognitive Grammar and to describe aspects of the English grammar in a meaningful and usage-based way. They will learn to analyze samples of language in Cognitive Grammar categories and determine the underlying mental processes. They will describe and discuss ways to apply Cognitive Grammar to second language teaching. Moreover, they will learn to read and present empirical papers and prepare to write seminar papers on the topic. The seminar and all readings are in English.

Addressees

This seminar is aimed at B.A. and teacher students of English who have completed the module Introduction to Linguistics and M.A. students of economic education ('Wirtschaftspädagogik').

Date	Topic	Preparatory reading	Additional reading
10-17-2017	Introduction and basic assumptions	—	—
10-24-2017	Categories in thought and language	Radden and Dirven (2007, ch. 1)	—
10-31-2017	Holiday	—	—
11-07-2017	Cognitive operations in thought and language	Radden and Dirven (2007, ch. 2)	—
11-14-2017	From thought to language: Cognitive Grammar	Radden and Dirven (2007, ch. 3)	—
11-21-2017	How to read and present scientific research	Bourne (2007)	—
11-28-2017	Types of things: Nouns	Radden and Dirven (2007, ch. 4)	Middleton et al. (2004, exp. 1 and 3)
12-05-2017	Grounding things: Reference	Radden and Dirven (2007, ch. 5)	Arnold and Griffin (2007)
12-12-2017	Quantifying things: Quantifiers	Radden and Dirven (2007, ch. 6)	Brooks and Braine (1996)
12-19-2017	Qualifying things: Modifiers	Radden and Dirven (2007, ch. 7)	Fox and Thompson (1990)
		Winter break	
01-09-2018	How to write a seminar paper	Schmidtke-Bode (ms)	
01-16-2018	Situation types: Aspect	Radden and Dirven (2007, ch. 8)	Taylor (2008)
01-23-2018	Grounding situations in time: Tense	Radden and Dirven (2007, ch. 9)	Niemeier and Reif (2008)
01-30-2018	Event schemas: Sentence patterns	Radden and Dirven (2007, ch. 11)	De Knop and Dirven (2008)
02-06-2018	Review, seminar paper proposals, evaluation	—	—

Requirements and grading system

Your grade will depend on a **seminar paper** (submission **deadlines 03-30-2018 and 05-30-2018**). Your paper needs to be between twelve and 15 pages long and follow the guideline by Schmidtke-Bode (ms). To be admitted to the seminar paper, a visible commitment to the seminar (continual and active **participation**) is required. **You're allowed to miss class twice**. Moreover, weekly preparation in the form of readings and accompanying homework will be required (see **Weekly requirements**). In addition, you need to present an additional reading in class at least once. Last, you need to present a seminar paper proposal in class (see **One-time requirements**).

Weekly requirements: Readings and questions

Each week, you need to read the listed **preparatory reading**. Moreover, you need to hand in a **written question** about the respective reading on Wordwise (see **Wordwise**). Your question needs to be at least 100 words long. You need to hand in at least eight questions. The question is **due each week on Sunday before the seminar, 12 midnight**.

One-time requirements: Presentation and proposal

You need to **present an additional reading** in class at least once. Your presentation should be 20 minutes long and will be followed by 10 minutes of discussion and feedback. Follow the rules for good presentations outlined by Bourne (2007). At the end of the seminar, you need to present a **seminar paper proposal** in class. Your proposal needs to be at least 300 words long, should include a topic, research question, some examples, and a rough outline of your argumentation, and needs to be handed in on Wordwise **by Sunday, 02-04-2018, 12 midnight**.

Wordwise

You find readings and materials on the online platform of our department, Wordwise. Important information on the organization of the course will also be distributed via Wordwise (to your email address). Please enroll in this seminar on Wordwise (the password was announced in class) and stay updated. You also need to hand in your weekly questions and your seminar paper proposal on Wordwise.

Requirements overview

Requirement	Due date	Where
Eight preparatory questions	Sunday before class, 12 midnight	Wordwise
Presentation additional reading	_____	in class
Hand in seminar paper proposal	02-04-2018, 12 midnight	Wordwise
Present seminar paper proposal	02-06-2018	in class
Seminar paper, 1st attempt	03-30-2018, 12 midnight	email and postbox
Seminar paper, 2nd attempt	05-30-2018, 12 midnight	email and postbox

References

Arnold, J. E. & Griffin, Z. M. (2007). The effect of additional characters on choice of referring expression: Everyone counts. *Journal of memory and language*, *56*(4), 521–536. doi:10.1016/j.jml.2006.09.007

Bourne, P. E. (2007). Ten simple rules for making good oral presentations. *PLoS Computational Biology*, *3*(4), e77. doi:10.1371/journal.pcbi.0030077

Brooks, P. J. & Braine, M. D. (1996). What do children know about the universal quantifiers all and each? *Cognition*, *60*(3), 235–268. doi:10.1016/0010-0277(96)00712-3

De Knop, S. & Dirven, R. (2008). Motion and location events in German, French and English: A typological, contrastive and pedagogical approach. In *Cognitive approaches to pedagogical grammar: A volume in honour of René Dirven* (pp. 298–324). Berlin: De Gruyter. doi:10.1515/9783110205381.3.295

Fox, B. A. & Thompson, S. A. (1990). A discourse explanation of the grammar of relative clauses in english conversation. *Language*, *66*(2), 297–316. doi:10.2307/414888

Langacker, R. W. (1987). *Foundations of cognitive grammar: Theoretical prerequisites*. Stanford University Press.

Langacker, R. W. (1991). *Foundations of cognitive grammar: Descriptive application*. Stanford University Press.

Langacker, R. W. (2008). *Cognitive grammar: A basic introduction*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Middleton, E. L., Wisniewski, E. J., Trindel, K. A., & Imai, M. (2004). Separating the chaff from the oats: Evidence for a conceptual distinction between count noun and mass noun aggregates. *Journal of Memory and Language*, *50*(4), 371–394. doi:10.1016/j.jml.2004.02.005

Niemeier, S. & Reif, M. (2008). Making progress simpler? Applying cognitive grammar to tense-aspect teaching in the German EFL classroom. In *Cognitive approaches to pedagogical grammar: A volume in honour of René Dirven* (pp. 325–355). Berlin: De Gruyter. doi:10.1515/9783110205381.3.325

Radden, G. & Dirven, R. (2007). *Cognitive English grammar*. John Benjamins. doi:10.1075/clip.2

Schmidtke-Bode, K. (ms). *Practical guidelines for writing a paper in linguistics*. online, Jena.

Taylor, J. R. (2008). Some pedagogical implications of cognitive linguistics. In *Cognitive approaches to pedagogical grammar: A volume in honour of René Dirven* (pp. 37–65). Berlin: De Gruyter. doi:10.1515/9783110205381.1.37

Note: I reserve the right to alter this syllabus (dates, readings, assignments, et. al.) during the semester when I deem it necessary.